
Fat and Jolly

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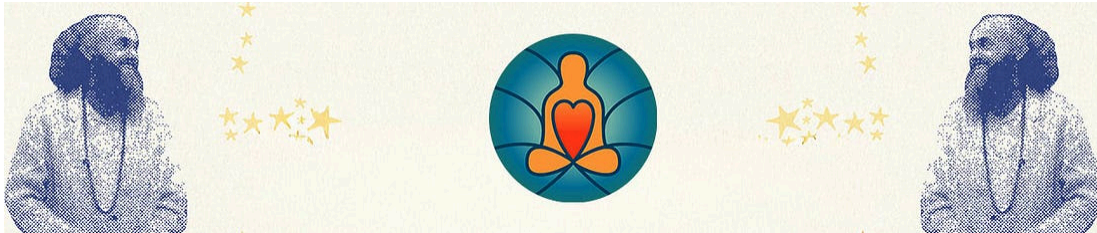
Fri, Sep 11, 2026 at 5:07 PM

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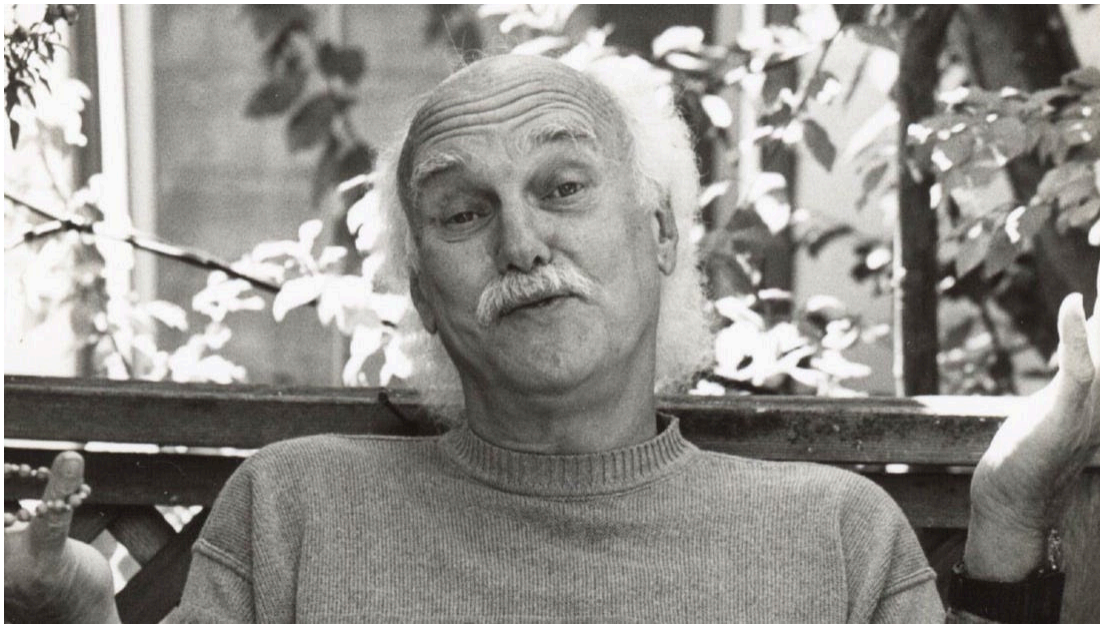
In this clip from an aging conference in the 1990s, Ram Dass opens up about his lifelong struggle with feeling fat, and how it's interesting to shift our perception surrounding food.

RAM DASS

SEP 11



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One of the many things I love about Ram Dass was his willingness to be so open about himself and his struggles in his human incarnation. I don't know about you, but I'm still trying to wrap my head around the fact that I am human, not some perfect being, and I do make mistakes once in a while (or on a daily basis, depending on who you ask). To listen to someone like Ram Dass be so refreshingly honest about these things is sweet music to my ears.

This is especially true when it comes to issues with food, dieting, and weight. Like Ram Dass, I've spent much of my life feeling fat. Not just feeling fat, but identifying myself as a "fat" person. So I'll work hard to lose the weight, then put it back on. Then lose it again, then put it back on.

And the cycle continues to this day. I've put on too much weight once again. I'm feeling fat, trapped under too many layers of flesh that I neither want nor need. So here I am, trying to regain my balance; trying to remind myself that there is fat, not "I am fat." And, as Ram Dass suggests in this clip, I'm trying to shift my perception around food a little bit.

— Noah Markus, Archivist, Love Serve Remember Foundation

Ram Dass:

I mean, I remember the years when my mother was being pulled, tied into corsets. You know, “Pull a little harder, would you?” Some of you must remember that stage of the universe. I just thought that was a natural thing, that you touched your mother and felt like steel all the way around, because basically, it was.

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And then she got her enlarged spleen, which made her look pregnant, which embarrassed her immensely because it made her look fat and big. And then she had the spleen removed, and she died from that. But she felt better.

And then six months later, I was sitting in front of this guy who had a big belly like this, and nobody cared. You never even noticed that. You just studied the beauty of the form. It was like a huge golden mountain.

See, this had a very impressive effect on me. His weight was a different kind of weight because it came from something about karma that I don't understand. But he would eat 40 meals at a sitting. He'd just go from house to house, and each woman had prepared food for the guru, and he would turn none of them away. He'd just keep eating and eating and eating and eating and eating. Now you can interpret it that he was a big pig, or that there was another game going.

And the way it affected me personally, or has been affecting me, was that when I was a child, my mother and I had our love affair through food. So basically she expressed her love by cooking for me, and I expressed my love by eating it. And I got fatter and fatter and fatter until, when I was about 13, I was in double Z trousers, which my mother would yell across the Filene's Basement floor, “I'm looking for double Z trousers,” much to my humiliation.

And my brother called me satchel ass, and all kinds of horrible things happened.

At any rate, then I became a yogi, and I was in India, and I was six foot two, and I went down to 140 pounds so that every rib was showing. I mean, my stomach was like this from doing the breathing exercises, way in. I can't even get there now. And boy, was I yogic-looking. And I still thought I was fat. And I had been dieting ever since I was a teenager, always dieting. And no matter how thin I got, I wanted to diet more because I always felt fat.

And so until about, I'd say, five years ago, ten years ago, I always was on a diet. I mean, life was a diet. Instead of just letting go of my attachment to food, I was busy dieting. Do you see the choice I had? I still wanted all the food.

Like, I just spent seven nights in a very fancy Berlin hotel in which every meal was a buffet, which is a killer for somebody like me. Because all this food was prepared by my mother, and I have to eat it all to show her I love her, or the chef's going to be hurt, or somebody's going to be hurt.

But then I saw that I was always dieting out of a preoccupation with attractiveness. Attractive to who? How? And I had an interesting moment. I taught with a group of rabbis at a Jewish summer camp, and one of the parts of the Jewish summer camp was that we all took the *Mikveh*. The men all go in to bathe together; they all bathe naked together. And it's a purification process. And then the women do it with each other.

And I got into this tub with these men, and I looked, and I saw that because we all came from Poland or Russia and were from peasant stock, we were all basically shaped the same way. And no matter how hard I tried, I wasn't going to be Tom Cruise or Arnold Schwarzenegger or something like that. I mean, I definitely had a different trip going, and they had the same trip, and why don't we just relax since that was our trip? Why do I have to make believe I have no ethnic roots, you know? Or something like that.

So at that point, something really deep happened to me, and I started to eat everything I wanted to because I decided I'd be attractive within my ethnicity, within my genetics, rather than in spite of it. Although the cultural definition of

beauty has very little appreciation for genetics, as you can see. So I ballooned up to now, where I'm about 220, and I'm fat and jolly.

However, this feels pretty unconscious to me because I can see that I am setting the groundwork for a lot of stuff with my body as time goes on, and I will later say, wouldn't it have been interesting had I attended to more what I put into it, as well as what comes out of it? I mean, it's a great thing to not notice what goes in and only what comes out. But if you got a choice, notice both of them. And also issues of exercise and yoga and things like that.

So I am a work in process. Because I'm just coming to the point where I would consider changing my diet out of just maintenance of the temple of my body. Not in an obsessive way. I'm not going to get neurotic about it, but I want to be reasonable about it. I want to play... What am I saying? For the long term? No, I don't think so. I don't think it has to do with duration as much as quality.

Like, I play golf on Tuesday mornings at the Mill Valley golf course with a man who's 80 years old and a man who's 76 or 78. And the 80-year-old guy is out there every day, a retired brigadier general, and he's just plowing along. And it's interesting because the quality of his life—I mean, the quality of his mind is strange, but... that's a political judgment—but the quality of his body, he's got good quality of life. I can see that in a way.

So, I see now that up until now I would diet for attractiveness, and now I would diet for health. But I see that is still a negative way of going about it. And the whole idea of diet is pitting yourself against a desire system you treat as if it's real. And maybe it would be better to extricate yourself from that desire system, which is the model of eating everything you want or eating whenever you want, or whatever it is, or thinking you're supposed to eat because you feel these certain things in your stomach.

And it's interesting to just start to shift your perception of food. I mean, that's what vegetarianism is... macrobiotics. You just shift the value play. So that's sort of where I am. I'm sure many of you are way ahead of that. I'm just showing you the beginning of my thing.

See, I see the energy that goes into keeping the body young and attractive in the culture.

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